



LAL KRISHNA
ADVANI

4

81, Leader of the
Opposition 5

BAHDEEP SINGH

Grand Maratha

Because he has emerged as a potential prime ministerial candidate without throwing his hat in the ring and has supporters both within the Government and the Opposition even though he has only nine MPs. **Because** he is one of Manmohan Singh's chief troubleshooters, helping him build consensus with allies on issues such as the nuclear deal.

Because he can take credit for a record foodgrain production of over 230 million tonnes and of 28 million tonnes of oilseeds this year.

Because by 2010, he will become the king of cricket when he takes over as president of the ICC.

smart move After the 26/11 Mumbai attacks, took the moral high ground away from the Congress by making NCP leader and deputy chief minister R.R. Patil resign before Congress chief minister Vilasrao Deshmukh.

little known fact An atheist, he rarely goes to temples and has never taken an oath of office in the name of God.

and finally Gave up his carefully-nurtured Lok Sabha seat, Baramati, for his daughter Supriya Sule and has shifted to another constituency, Shirur, which is not held by the NCP. He is, however, confident of winning.

Man for all Reasons

Because he is the UPA's Mr Fix-It-All, chairing Cabinet meetings in the prime minister's absence, presiding over 60 Groups of Ministers, heading the Congress manifesto committee, and acting as the first port of call in case of trouble for both the prime minister and Congress president.

Because he is the key communicator with unpredictable allies like the Samajwadi Party and Mamata Banerjee's Trinamool Congress.

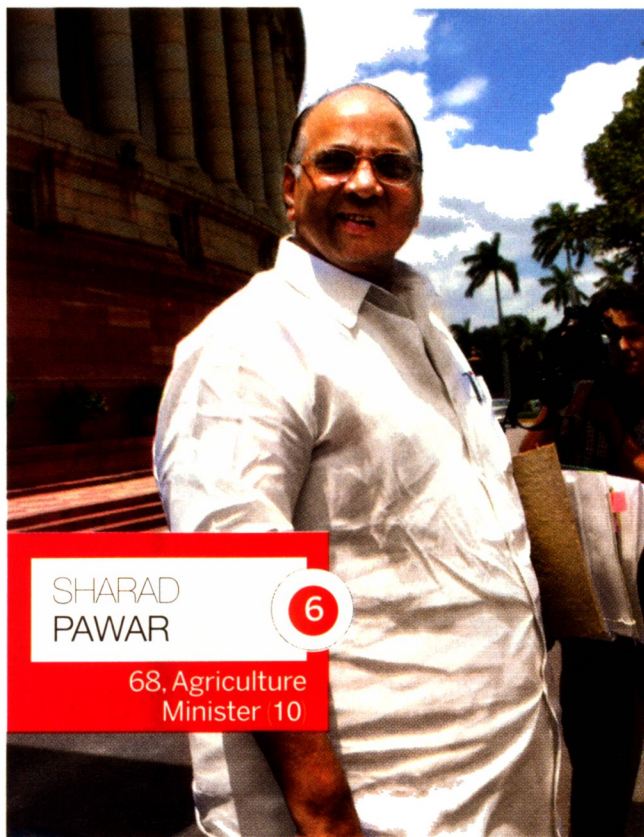
Because as India's top diplomat, he has a direct line to world leaders, whether it's Bangladesh premier Sheikh Hasina or US Secretary of State Hillary Clinton.

cannot do without Attending his family Durga puja at Mirati village in West Bengal.

hot wheels A fleet of bulletproof army Ambassadors from his Defence Ministry days and a dedicated Indian Air Force Embraer aircraft to ferry him.

best-kept secret Is working on his autobiography in Bengali which promises to be a political bestseller.

the irony He is not good enough to be the prime minister or President, yet is 'indispensable'.



SHARAD
PAWAR

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68, Agriculture
Minister 10

SIFRA DAS